

In the backseat: Jessica Pegula had no answer to Sabalenka's power game and lost 7-5, 6-2 in their semifinal. AP

errors, compared with seven and 18 for Rybakina. The Kazakh countered by targeting the American's vulnerable forehand and subtly changing pace and bounce heights to take the second set 6-4.

Gauff revived hopes for yet another comeback when, trailing 5-3 in the deciding set, she broke Rybakina's mighty serve for 5-4, highlighted by a dazzling backhand passing shot that had the crowd roaring. But Rybakina broke right back with a stylish forehand volley winner followed by Gauff's errant smash for a well-deserved 3-6, 6-4, 6-4 triumph.

'Pressure is a privilege' is the famous axiom coined by Billie Jean King. It appears on the commemorative plaque at the players' walkway to Arthur Ashe Stadium at the USTA Billie Jean King National Tennis Center. Pressure inspires some athletes to perform at extraordinary levels. And pressure overwhelms other athletes who falter on the biggest stages.

Sabalenka falls into the latter category. All too often, she lost in three sets to seemingly lesser players and at the end of tournaments. At this US Open, she reached her eighth straight Grand Slam final on a hard court — a feat never achieved before by a man or woman. Overall, the finely tuned Belarusian has made nine Major finals, including the 2025 French Open. Yet she has won only four of these.

The emotional cauldron that is Sabalenka boiled over and exploded on occasion against Rybakina, who possesses a preternatural, Borg-like calmness.

When she whacked a ball into the crowd after double-faulting to gift Rybakina a 3-2 lead, the umpire gave her a warning. Sabalenka grunted, shrieked or screamed with every shot, and when she misfired, she gesticulated her displeasure, barked

at her player box, or gave coaches Anton Dubrov, Max Mirnyi and Jason Stacy sarcastic thumbs-up. Serving at 3-4, 30-15, Sabalenka inexplicably didn't run for Rybakina's service return. The more consistent and serene Rybakina grabbed the opening set 6-4. Loss of emotional control didn't cause this Sabalenka loss, however. The superior play of Rybakina, particularly her powerful and precise serving, did.

With Rybakina serving at 4-5 in the second set, Sabalenka earned two set points. The crowd roared to support Sabalenka. She failed to convert them, but two games later, she broke serve with a booming backhand service return to take the second set 7-5. Both players won 71

points. The protagonists had also split their 46 career sets at 23 apiece!

That parity would end in the lopsided deciding set. Rybakina broke serve for a 2-1 lead. Serving at 15-all in the next game, the Kazakh had her opponent scrambling and finished her off with a nifty backhand winner. **Rybakina reacted with a rare fist pump. A forehand volley winner produced another break for 5-2. And despite two double faults in the last game, Rybakina clinched her first US Open title with a 110-mph ace.**

Ultimate test: Despite her speed and agility, Coco Gauff couldn't overcome the relentless Rybakina in the other semifinal. GETTY IMAGES

